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Measuring service quality in local government: the SERVQUAL approach

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There can be little doubt that quality and customer service are the critical strategic issues in the 1990s for both public and private sector organizations. In the private sector, customer satisfaction and loyalty – secured through high-quality products and services providing value for money for the consumer – are seen as essential for long-term survival, let alone long-term success. Public sector organizations, and those operating in local government specifically, are not immune from these pressures to improve customer service on a continuous basis. Some of these pressures arise internally within local authorities from a genuine desire by managers to improve the quality of services provided to local citizens; others are "imposed" through initiatives like Citizen's Charter, or through an increase in consumer activism.

It is recognized that public sector organizations face more difficulties than those in the private sector in their efforts to improve customer service. For a private sector organization, service quality initiatives have little to do with the social good but are intended to enhance the organization's bottom line – its long-term profitability. As such, investment in these initiatives can be assessed, justified, and obtained on the basis of generating a financial pay-back. In the current public sector financial environment, customer service initiatives often have to be funded on a shoestring or resourced through budget reallocation away from other activities.

Equally, a private sector organization usually finds it relatively easy to define its customers – both existing and potential. They are those people who are prepared to pay the prevailing market price for the product or service in question. In contrast, most public sector organizations have a variety of "customers" for their different services. Some of these are similar to the private sector customer paying directly or indirectly for services provided and received. Others are the recipients or users of services – sometimes unwillingly – but make little or no financial contribution towards their provision. Yet another type of customer again may pay for a particular public service but not experience its benefits through direct use. The role of other stakeholders, and of elected members in particular, is ambiguous in this respect.

For example, councillors have traditionally represented the customers as service recipients and yet, at the same time, have the responsibility of directing the

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resources underpinning service provision as well as the duty of acting as community guardians of the public purse. These various customer groups may well have different and contrasting opinions on current levels of service provision, causing additional problems for the local government manager in terms of priorities in customer service improvement.

None of these factors, however, negate the need for local government managers to seek constantly to improve customer service. They simply reinforce the fact that methods for monitoring, assessing and evaluating levels of customer service need to be rigorous, adaptable and suitably sophisticated. The obvious approach, in terms of assessing current levels of service quality, is to ask the customer (however defined for a particular service area). Indeed, it is worth pointing out the obvious: at the end of the day the customer is the sole judge of service quality. The second obvious point to make is how easy it is for managers in local government to forget this.

The obvious approach – asking the customer – can be fraught with difficulties, however. A major problem is that customer satisfaction surveys – an increasing, and expensive, phenomenon in the public sector – are prone to focus on customer *perceptions* of service delivery: what the customers think of the quality of service delivered. These surveys rarely provide the customer with any opportunity of articulating their *expectations* of service quality. This may be particularly important if such customer feedback is to be useful to policy makers and service managers. Customers typically assess service quality by comparing the service they have actually experienced (the perceived service quality) with the service they desire or expect (their expected service quality). Without adequate information about both expectations and perceptions, the feedback from customer surveys is downright dangerous.

But there are other potential problems with conventional customer satisfaction surveys. Unless considerable care and professionalism is applied, such surveys may lie open to the charge of bias in their construction, their wording, or their sampling frame. Such surveys also often reflect those service characteristics or features regarded as important by service managers and these may or may not coincide with the features that the customer views as important. Again, such surveys often take on gargantuan proportions in that they seek to collect customer opinions on every possible aspect of service provision, with little thought given to subsequent analysis and use of the data collected. Often constructed to respond to a crisis or emergency – such as an imminent review by the relevant service committee – these surveys are rarely embedded in the management monitoring processes or in the decision-making structures which would be able to take appropriate actions based on their findings. As such, customer satisfaction surveys are often little more than rituals to convince key stakeholders that efforts are being taken to be "close to the customer" and to improve service quality based on customer feedback. At worst such surveys can disguise fundamental problems in service provision that need to be addressed as a matter of urgency.

This is not to say that customer feedback is not required. Rather, the right form of feedback is needed – both in terms of expectations and perceptions of

service quality – and this feedback must be obtained in a rigorous but cost-effective manner to feed directly into management monitoring and performance review systems. Indeed, current – and continuing – resource pressures, along with firm policy directions from central government, give added urgency for local government decision makers to understand and manage the needs and expectations of its various customer groups better and to be aware of customers' perceptions as they apply to current service quality. Not only will such knowledge facilitate more informed prioritization, improved strategic resource allocation, and improved value for money, it will also serve as a platform for providing better services for citizens; better in the sense that they more closely match customers' expectations.

The continuing move to more autonomous and less centralized decision making along with the increasing importance of contract-based service provision, adds weight to the arguments for establishing clear, meaningful performance criteria and for mechanisms by which service quality can be measured, monitored and ultimately improved. These mechanisms, however, need to be rigorous and methodical and not *ad hoc*.

One such potential mechanism is the SERVQUAL model originally developed in 1985 by Parasuraman *et al.*[1] and subsequently refined as a general methodology for measuring service quality in a variety of organizations, both private and public sector. The SERVQUAL model identifies specific criteria by which customers evaluate service quality. These criteria are classed in five major dimensions:

(1) *Tangibles*. The appearance of physical facilities, equipment, personnel, and communications materials.

(2) *Reliability*. The ability to perform the promised service dependably and accurately.

(3) *Responsiveness*. The willingness to help customers and provide prompt service.

(4) *Assurance*. The competence of the system and its credibility in providing a courteous and secure service.

(5) *Empathy*. The approachability, ease of access and effort taken to understand customers' needs.

At the heart of the model is a structured set of statements in questionnaire format designed to assess these five dimensions in the context of a single service provider. The questionnaire design was arrived at after considerable empirical psychometric testing and trials so that it could be applied across a broad range of service organizations with only minor modification. It is, however, easily adapted to fit a specific service environment.

The model begins with the assumption that customers are able to articulate both their *expectations* of the general characteristics and determinants of quality service and also their *perceptions* of actual and current service quality for a specific service provider. The model therefore not only provides an assessment of customer views of current service quality; it also provides a yardstick in terms

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of their expectations of what that service quality should be. For each statement, the respondent is provided with a seven-point Likert scale ranging from "strongly agree" to "strongly disagree". They are then asked to score their expectations of the service and later to score their perceptions of the service actually experienced from the organization under examination. So, for example, a question relating to the reliability dimension might be: "An excellent housing repair service will provide their services at the time they promise to do so". Later in the questionnaire the related statement appears: "Midtown housing department provides its services at the time it promises to do so."

Such a questionnaire structure – comprising between 20 and 30 statements around the five dimensions – allows analysis in a number of ways:

- assessing which service dimensions score highly in terms of customer expectations – for example whether customers place more value on tangibles or on reliability;
- assessing how these different service features are rated by the customer – on the basis of their actual experience – for the specific service provider being investigated;
- assessing the gap between customers' expectations of the service and their perceived experience of the service actually delivered overall and for each of the service quality dimensions.

This last point is a particularly important outcome of the SERVQUAL model. If, in the illustrative question used earlier, the tenant had strongly agreed with the statement in the expectation section but strongly disagreed with the corresponding statement in relation to the actual service received, then clearly a major gap exists – in the tenant's mind – between the service that should be provided and the service that is currently being delivered. This approach may sound unduly simplistic but it is in fact supported through the model with sophisticated statistical analysis. This allows a rigorous and testable analysis of the customer responses.

Further, the SERVQUAL questionnaire invites customers to allocate weights to each of the five dimensions of service quality which reflect their relative importance from the customer's perspective. Aggregating these weights in line with the size of the gaps identified in the other sections of the questionnaire allows an assessment of the "focus" of the organization. For example, the questionnaire might reveal that in the tangibles dimension, customer expectations of service quality are being exceeded. However, customers might indicate through their relative weightings that the tangibles dimension is seen as relatively unimportant to the overall quality of the service. The SERVQUAL approach therefore allows an organization to determine, in a rigorous and quantifiable way, if its resources are well-focused on the service quality dimensions that are deemed to be important by the customer – clearly an important aspect in today's (and tomorrow's) financial and political climate.

SERVQUAL, however, has the potential for investigating more than just the gap between customer expectations and customer perceptions of service quality.

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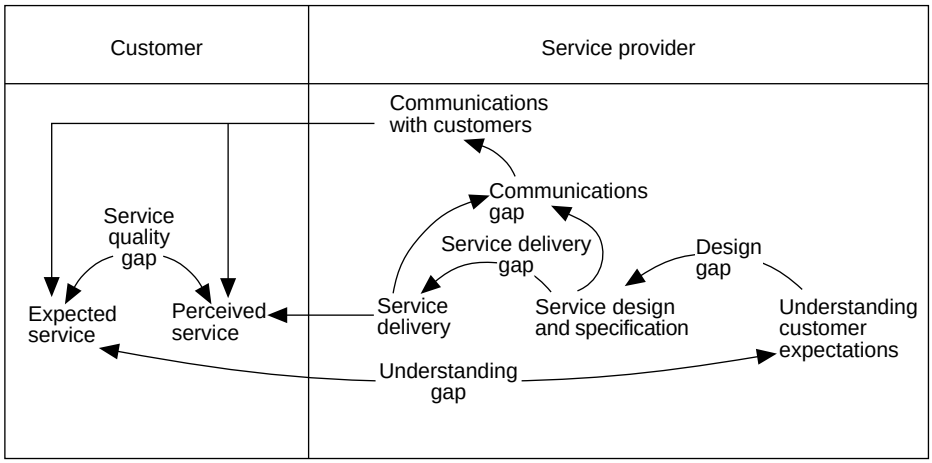
If reliable and valid in a local government environment, the identification of a deficit score in one or more dimension will normally be evidence of a deeper underlying problem. Statistically significant gaps between customer expectations and perceptions in any dimension should only be the starting point for the investigation into how service quality can be improved, and not the conclusion as is often the case with more superficial customer satisfaction surveys.

In principle, the SERVQUAL model can be extended to investigate five possible gaps in the process of service delivery in meeting customer expectations. These are illustrated in Figure 1.

The service quality gap is the gap between customer expectations of the service and the perceived service delivered and is the gap on which many service organizations frequently focus. However, simply looking at this gap and searching for solutions to help close it might not, by itself, be adequate in terms of matching customer expectations. Other gaps in the service process may be contributing to such service shortfalls and must be identified and dealt with directly by managers if service quality is ultimately to be improved.

The understanding gap is the gap between customer expectations and management perceptions of what these customer expectations are. If there is a mismatch then management in the service provider organization must understand customer expectations adequately if the right priorities are to be set, the right resource allocations made, and the right corrective actions taken. Such a gap may be caused by inadequate research into customer needs; poor internal communications., or inadequate management structures.

The design gap is the gap between management's understanding of customer expectations and the design and specification of service quality. Management understanding of customer expectations must be accurately translated into appropriate quality specifications and performance standards. Such a gap might



Source: Adapted from [2]

Figure 1.
Service quality gaps

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be caused by an inadequate commitment to service quality; inappropriate goal setting; or by management who are inexperienced or inadequate in this area.

The delivery gap is that between the specification of service quality and the actual quality of the service delivered. Such a gap may arise because of a shortage of resources in key areas; lack of commitment and motivation; inadequate quality control procedures; or inadequate staff training.

Finally, *the communications gap* is that between what is actually delivered and what has been promised in terms of external communications such as media, service publicity, local and national charters, customer contracts and the like.

Essentially, the SERVQUAL approach assesses the size of each of these gaps and their resulting impact on the imbalance between customers' expectations and experiences as measured in the service quality gap.

The implications of this approach will be evident. A standard customer satisfaction survey will typically focus on attitudes to services currently being provided and suffer from some of the drawbacks previously discussed. As a consequence, the local government manager reacting to such survey findings may well embark on inappropriate courses of action or initiatives. For example, negative responses from customers to a specific part of the service might motivate change to be instituted. As Figure 1 and the discussion of gap determinants above illustrates, however, the fundamental causes of dissatisfaction might lie deeper within the organization. Initiatives taken in response to customer criticism might simply be treating the symptom of the problem and not its root cause. Moreover, an adequate understanding of customer expectations – as well as their past experiences – allows managerial judgement to be exercised from a position of knowledge rather than guesswork in the important task of managing public expectations and resources.

Early results of studies applying the SERVQUAL approach to public sector organizations in the UK indicate that managers frequently over-estimate customer expectations. Ongoing work piloting the approach in local government service provision confirms this view and has identified a number of modifications to the methodology required to improve the validity of the approach in this arena. As a diagnostic tool to uncover symptoms of service quality shortfalls and establish a starting point for the investigation of deeper problems, the SERVQUAL approach merits detailed consideration by local government managers who seriously wish to assess service quality in a rigorous and testable manner. The approach is readily adapted to investigate the quality of internal as well as direct service provision and offers a mechanism both for tracking service quality over time and for comparing service quality between departments in a council or, indeed, between different authorities.

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